and fifty men along with a lama guide occupying PT 10000 to the northwest of Kibithu. Just below this height was PT 9000 where the Kumaonis CO, Madiah, deployed the Assam Rifles platoon. According to the existing 'rules of engagement' only Assam Rifles troops could confront the Chinese, a factor that made the 6 Kumaon move forward even more puzzling. The next day, as the two sides faced off, Madiah decided to reinforce the McMahon Ridge with a platoon from Alpha Company under the command of Major S. G. Naygam. He also asked Delta Company under the command of Captain T. S. Pall to move from The Ladders to Kibithu while Bravo Company under Major B. N. Sharma was told to move from the East Ridge to the Kibithu DZ. Pall would be in position by 20 October while Sharma was expected to reach the DZ on 22 October, thus pulling the entire battalion into Kibithu.

The news of the Chinese assault on 7 Infantry Brigade on the Nam Ka Chu on 20 October combined with the steady build-up of Chinese forces in the area around Sama clearly indicated that the Chinese were preparing themselves for a major assault. An uneasy calm prevailed till 7 p.m. on 21 October when a few Very lights arched into the night sky. A barrage of mortar and artillery fire simultaneously targeted both the McMahon Ridge and The Top in the Dichu Valley. After half an hour of intense shelling, Chinese infantry began their advance on the two Indian posts.

The Chinese were met with both rifle and 3-inch mortar fire, the latter being directed by Naik Bahadur Singh. The Indians were always most effective when they fought the Chinese from their fixed positions, the .303 Lee Enfield rifles taking a deadly toll of the enemy. The first attack on McMahon Ridge fizzled out, but it was followed by a second wave as the Chinese moved forward in overwhelming numbers. Bahadur Singh had by then abandoned the mortars and had grabbed the LMG from the two gunners of his section who had both been wounded. Fighting ferociously, he attracted heavy fire and was hit by a machine gun burst that killed him instantly.

After four hours of fighting, Major Naygam had also been wounded. Surprisingly, at that stage, casualties on the Indian side were relatively light —three killed and six wounded—a phenomenon that was to repeat itself whenever the Indians fought from their prepared defences (1 Sikh at Bum-la and 4 Garhwal Rifles at Nuranang). The fighting had by then spread to a third post, The Hump, which was occupied by a section of Assam Rifles.